

# Carrier Delay - Agent Knowledge Base

How to classify delayed shipments, set expectations, start traces, and decide when refund or replacement becomes available.

## Prototype disclaimer

Synthetic sample policy for prototyping and RAG evaluation. This document is fictional operational guidance, not a statement of any real company's policy. Adapt, validate, and approve it before production use.

## Retrieval metadata

**Applies to:** customer support agents, ticket triage agents, and automated support agents

**Recommended ticket tags:** carrier\_delay, stalled\_shipment, late\_delivery, customs\_hold, return\_to\_sender

**Policy status:** synthetic / test corpus

## Policy summary

A carrier delay is a shipment that has been physically accepted by the carrier but is moving slower than the current delivery estimate or has an explicit carrier exception. Agents should avoid refunding solely because an ETA slipped unless the order crosses the defined delay threshold.

### Delay thresholds

Standard domestic: escalate for resolution when the parcel is 5 calendar days beyond the latest carrier ETA. Expedited domestic: 2 calendar days beyond ETA. International: 10 calendar days beyond ETA, unless customs status requires a different action.

## Decision rules

| Situation                                          | Agent action                                                                                                                       | Escalate when                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Shipment is late but still receiving scans         | Apologize, share latest scan, and give revised carrier ETA.                                                                        | Threshold is exceeded or scan shows exception/return-to-sender.                       |
| No movement after carrier acceptance               | Treat as stalled after 3 business days with no event. Start carrier trace.                                                         | No movement continues for 2 business days after trace or delay threshold is exceeded. |
| Weather or network disruption is posted by carrier | Explain disruption and avoid firm promises.                                                                                        | Shipment crosses the resolution threshold.                                            |
| Customs hold                                       | Explain customs processing may require customer/carrier action. Ask whether carrier requested documents or fees.                   | Hold exceeds 10 calendar days or carrier requests shipper action.                     |
| Return to sender                                   | Do not ask customer to keep waiting for delivery. Verify reason and use refund/replacement path once return movement is confirmed. | Address correction or reship authorization is needed.                                 |

## Resolution options after threshold

When the applicable threshold is exceeded, agents may offer one of the following if inventory and order eligibility allow: replacement shipment at no extra charge, or refund to the original payment method. Do not issue both for the same unit. If the customer chooses replacement and the original later arrives, follow the duplicate-delivery procedure defined by operations.

## Agent wording guidance

- Say "The carrier is delayed" when carrier data supports it; do not say "lost" until a trace or policy threshold supports that classification.
- Give the next action date, for example: "If there is no delivery by October 12, contact us and we can resolve this with a replacement or refund."
- Do not guarantee a carrier investigation outcome.

## Suggested ticket fields

issue\_type=carrier\_delay; carrier; service\_level; latest\_scan; latest\_scan\_time; current\_eta; days\_past\_eta; stalled=yes|no; carrier\_trace\_id; resolution\_eligible=yes|no; customer\_preference=wait|replace|refund

## Frequently asked questions

**Q: My delivery date passed. Can I get a refund now?**

A: Not automatically. If the parcel is still moving, compare it with the service-level threshold. A refund or replacement becomes available after the applicable delay threshold unless another policy applies.

**Q: When is a package considered stalled?**

A: After carrier acceptance, no tracking event for 3 business days is treated as stalled and should trigger a carrier trace.

**Q: What if weather caused the delay?**

A: Explain the carrier disruption and continue to use the same resolution threshold. Weather is not a reason to invent a new ETA.

**Q: Can I send a replacement before the threshold?**

A: Only through an approved exception, such as a verified critical-order program. Otherwise follow the normal threshold to avoid duplicate fulfillment.

**Q: What happens if the original arrives after a replacement?**

A: Do not charge the customer automatically. Follow the duplicate-delivery procedure or escalate if no procedure is available.

**Q: Customs has my parcel. Is that a carrier delay?**

A: Treat customs as a special international delay. Determine whether customer documents or fees are required, and escalate shipper-action requests.

### Agent response principle

State what is known, distinguish it from what is estimated, give the customer the next concrete step, and never promise an outcome outside the rules in this knowledge base.